

CRADLE OF EXCELLENCE
IIM-Ahmedabad, one of the top business schools in India

"I STOOD ON MY OWN FEET FOR THE FIRST TIME AT IIM-A"

FROM THE BAD GRADE OF A MISERABLE FIRST YEAR TO COMING OUT ON TOP BY WAY OF PRODUCTION DESIGN. PLUS, A LITTLE DHARNA

GUEST COLUMN | MALLIKA SARABHAI



I was admitted to IIM–Ahmedabad (IIM–A) at a very difficult time. In fact, I wrote the IIM exam on January 1, after cremating my father Vikram Sarabhai the previous evening. It was very hard and when I finally got to IIM-A, I had a complete nervous breakdown. Everyone thought that I had been taken on charity and was a very stupid person. It took four-five newly-made friends to basically teach me how to walk again. But the first year was hell. The teachers told me that had I not been Vikram Sarabhai's daughter, I would have gotten a C. "But because you are who you are, we don't want to be seen as being favourable to you. So we are giving you a D." I was basically struggling to get through and to pass.

But the next year was amazing. I came into my own. I found that I was very good at production design, which is usually the engineering specialisation. In fact, I climbed the charts and came out on top. Perhaps the most useful thing that I have learnt from IIM-A is a course called Written Analysis and Communication (WACK). Here you have to reduce a 100-page case study to a one-page executive summary, where you didn't leave anything out. And we all flunked it. But apparently, I must have become very good at it because it has stood me in great stead.

I hated finance, but now I spend most of my time doing finance—trying to run an arts institution that is not-for-profit and trying to keep people's motivation high. So, a lot of my organisational behaviour and a lot of finance have come into play on a daily basis. It was a very special two years. I made amazing friends, and in a way, I stood on my own feet for the first time.

In my year, there were nine girls in the class for the first time. There was no dormitory for us, so they pushed us into a kind of housing that we shared between the three of us, which was meant for one. It was horrible. So I sat on a dharna outside the then director Dr Samuel Paul's office till he promised to give us a dorm. Women had their own dorm for the first time in the second year. ■

The writer is an activist, Indian classical dancer and actor. She graduated from IIM-A in 1976